the recruitment exam paper leaks, law and order breakdown and failure to waive all farm loans to build up the tempo against the Gehlot government. Poonia must be wary: this could be his last chance to convince the high command and get himself a second term as state chief (his stint ended last month) and lead the party into the election.

Poonia's ineffectiveness was almost exposed when ex-BJP MLA Prahlad Gunjal announced a parallel rally in Kota on December 24, a day after the party's Jan Aakrosh rally there. At the last moment, the Gunjal-organised rally—which Raje was to address—was cancelled citing Covid threats, but party insiders say it would have overshadowed the official show.

There are a few reasons for the BJP's declining popularity in Rajasthan. In blaming Raje for the loss in 2018, the BJP high command overlooked certain crucial factors that it may be analysing now, after the recent defeats. Raje's government had lost the election by a margin of just over one per cent in vote share and, of course, like Himachal, the state has a history of electing new parties every five years. Besides, Rajasthan did not get any special assistance or project from the Centre during Raje's term that could have been projected to voters as a "double engine" advantage. That said, Raje and her government were guilty of underperforming.

Given the dull response to the Jan Aakrosh rallies, the buzz is the high command might go for an overhaul and induct a low-profile RSS favourite who is not too ambitious (a pre-poll formula used elsewhere in the north) to lead the campaign. Right now, there are a half-dozen leaders who are hoping to replace Raje as CM candidate if the party wins. They are out to cut each other down even as they know the BJP needs Raje to mobilise the masses. Unless the Modi-Shah duo are willing to risk losing Rajasthan just to show her up, the party has little choice but to let her lead another yatra like the ones she did in 2003 and 2013 to bring down earlier Gehlot-led governments. ■

UTTAR PRADESH

COSTLY OVERSIGHT

By Prashant Srivastava

A technical lapse could prove to be the undoing of the BJP's carefully cultivated OBC strategy in Uttar Pradesh. The cornerstone of successive victories for it stood in peril on December 27 as the Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court ruled that the state proceed with its urban local body elections without reservations for OBCs. Reason? The state government's failure to comply with the Supreme Court-mandated 'triple test'.

The Yogi Adityanath regime seems to have faltered on the very first step of the three laid down by the apex court in its March 2021 ruling—that is, to set up a dedicated data commission to assess backwardness insofar as it pertains to local bodies. The state instead relied on the old procedure of conducting a rapid survey to determine OBC populations in each municipal seat and reserve seats accordingly—a method deemed inadequate by the courts to determine appropriate political representation. Precisely why the triple test was mandated, its very idea being to arrive at meaningful proportions of reservation to ensure representation for the deserving in local administrations and to see the combined quotas for the underprivileged did not exceed 50 per cent.

This was to be the first time the triple test itself would be put to test. As it happens, that might not come to pass. On its part, the UP government challenged the high court ruling the very next day and also formed a five-member commission. There are 762 urban local bodies in UP, including 17 municipal corporations, 200 nagar palika parishads and 545 nagar panchayats. On December 5, the state government had issued a draft notification reserving 27 per cent of the seats in the ULBs. It was this order that the Allahabad HC overruled in its latest judgment.

Opposition parties are having a field day at this turn of events. OBC reservations had been snatched away, Dalits would be next, alleged Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, as he urged the twin cohort to support him. BSP supremo Mayawati seems to have found her voice too, as she accused the BJP of being anti-reservation in its mentality.

ANI



CAUGHT ON THE BACK FOOT, THE YOGI REGIME IS LIKELY TO USE ALL LEGAL MEANS POSSIBLE TO PROTECT OBC QUOTAS

Finding itself on the back foot, the government blamed its officers for not following the new format. Keshav Prasad Maurya, reappointed deputy CM despite losing in the 2022 assembly poll in a nod to the BJP's OBC outreach, issued a hasty reassurance that there was no question of holding local body polls without OBC reservation. All legal options will be accessed for that. ■